

THE AGEING WORKFORCE PARADOX

LONGER CAREERS, AI, AND SHIFTING
DEMOGRAPHICS ARE REWRITING THE
RULES OF WORK EXPERIENCE

BY **MAMTA SHARMA**

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FOR NEARLY THREE decades, Smitha M. V. (54) has built her career by doing something many professionals stop doing after reaching senior positions: starting over. From product engineering at Wipro to digital skilling at NASSCOM, start-ups, the gig economy and now Artificial Intelligence (AI), every transition demanded new skills and a new way of thinking. “Experience becomes valuable only when it evolves with the changing needs of business,” she says.

Her observation captures the dilemma facing millions of experienced professionals today. Companies say they value experience more than ever, yet many senior employees worry whether they are becoming less relevant in an AI-driven workplace.

“Technology evolves, industries transform, customer expectations shift, business priorities change,” she says. The ability to understand these

shifts and adapt quickly is becoming more valuable than deep expertise in a single area.

AI is the latest example. Experienced professionals do not need to become AI experts, she says, but they do need to understand how AI is changing work—and how it can create greater business value.

“The bigger lesson was that relevance comes from continuously understanding the context around you and adapting your skills to it.”

RETHINKING RETIREMENT

For Jamuna Ravi, CEO of Vayah Vikas, the conversation goes beyond employment. Vayah Vikas is a tech-driven community ecosystem that supports senior citizens through healthcare, digital literacy, financial independence, and active post-retirement engagement.

“Retirement marked the end of one’s primary professional identity for decades,” she says. “With longer life expectancy, better health and changing